AHAB AND THE WHALE

A duel on the open sea for two players. Ahab hunts the white whale; the winds decide where it runs.

2 players · Age 10+ · About 10 minutes a game

THE IDEA

Every card is a **wind**. The wind of the led card picks the line the whale moves along, and the trick decides which way along that line it goes.

Ahab wants the whale inside the **harpoon range** when the hand ends. **The Whale** wants it out on the **open sea**.

COMPONENTS

- **36 wind cards:** four winds, numbered 1 to 9 in each.

North · East · South · West

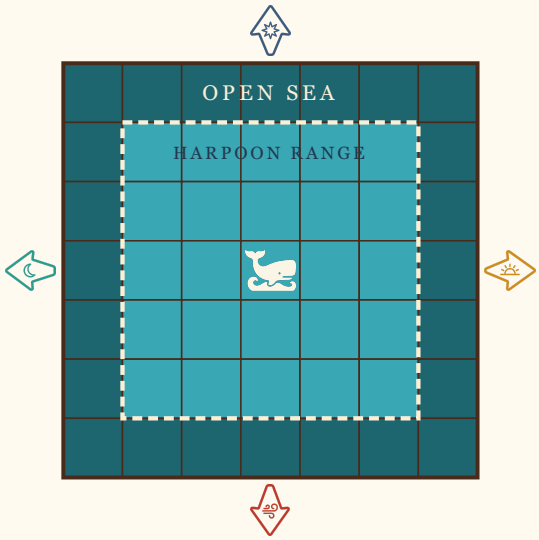
- **1 sea chart:** a 7×7 grid. The outer ring of 24 cells is the **open sea**. The inner 5×5 is the **harpoon range**.
- **1 whale.**
- **2 player aids.**

PLAYING WITH A STANDARD DECK

Use the Ace to 9 of each suit: ♠ North, ♥ East, ♦ South, ♣ West. An Ace counts as 1. Draw a 7×7 grid and use a coin for the whale.

SETUP

1. **Place the whale** on the centre cell of the sea chart.
2. **Choose roles.** One player is Ahab, the other is the Whale.
3. **Deal.** Shuffle the 36 cards and deal 12 to each player. Put the last 12 aside face down without looking at them; they are not used this game.
4. **Choose the first leader** at random.



The sea chart at the start. The whale sits on the centre cell. Each wind points the way shown.

PLAYING A TRICK

A hand is 12 tricks. Each trick:

1. **Lead.** The leader plays any card face up. Its wind is the wind of the trick.
2. **Follow.** The other player must play a card of the led wind if they can. If they cannot, they play any card. There are no trumps.
3. **Win the trick.** If the follower played the led wind, the higher number wins. If the follower could not, the leader wins. The winner leads the next trick. Set played cards aside.
4. **Move the whale one step:**

What happened	The whale moves one step
The leader won, and the follower followed	in the direction of the led wind
The follower won	the opposite way to the led wind
The follower could not follow (**drift**)	in the direction of the wind the follower discarded

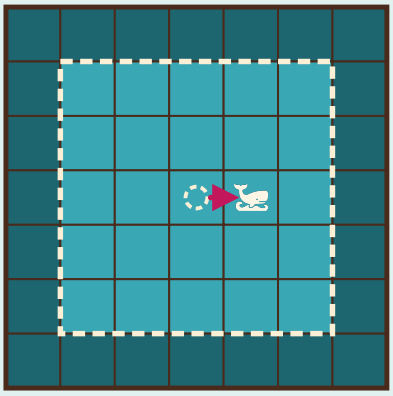
DRIFT

When the follower cannot follow, the leader still wins the trick and leads next. But the follower steers: the whale moves the way of the wind they discarded.

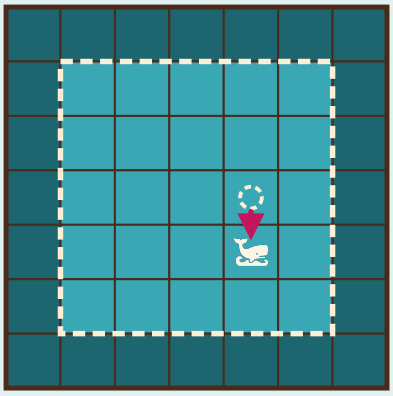
AT THE EDGE OF THE CHART

If a step would take the whale off the chart, it does not move. The whale may sit on the open sea during the hand and can be pulled back in. Only where it is at the end of the hand counts.

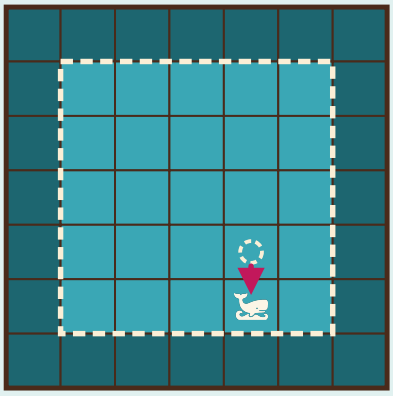
EXAMPLE: THREE TRICKS



1 The Whale leads East 9. Ahab follows East 4. The leader wins, so the whale moves one step East. The Whale leads next.



2 The Whale leads North 2. Ahab must follow and plays North 5. The follower wins, so the whale moves the opposite way: South. Ahab leads next.



3 Ahab leads West 6. The Whale has no West cards and discards South 3. Ahab wins and leads next, but the whale drifts one step South, the way of the discard.

END OF THE HAND

After the 12th trick, look at the whale:

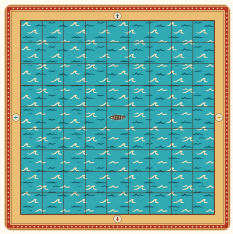
- **On the open sea:** the Whale wins.
- **In the harpoon range:** Ahab wins.

A game is one hand.

PLAYING A MATCH

Play two games, swapping roles. The player who did not lead first in the first game leads first in the second. Win both games to win the match; one game each is a draw.

VARIANT: THE LONG VOYAGE



All the rules above apply, with these changes:

- **Sea chart:** a 9×9 grid. The outer ring is the open sea; every cell inside it is harpoon range.
- **The wind never blows twice.** You may not lead the wind that was led on the previous trick, unless every card in your hand is that wind. Leave the last led card face up beside the chart as a reminder.
- **Up to three hands.** Before each hand, shuffle, deal 12 cards each and return the whale to the centre. Players take turns to lead the first trick of each hand.
- **End of a hand:** if the whale is on the open sea, the Whale wins the game at once. Otherwise Ahab scores the hand. Ahab wins the game when he scores his second hand.

QUICK REFERENCE

- **Setup:** whale on the centre cell; deal 12 each; 12 unused.
- **Lead** any card. Its wind is the wind of the trick.
- **Follow** the led wind if you can. No trumps.
- **Higher card of the led wind wins.** A follower who cannot follow loses the trick.
- **Whale moves one step:** leader won, the led way; follower won, the opposite way; follower could not follow, the discarded wind's way.
- **Off the chart?** The whale does not move.
- **After trick 12:** open sea, the Whale wins; harpoon range, Ahab wins.